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Nieuwe Instituut

Stress
Management

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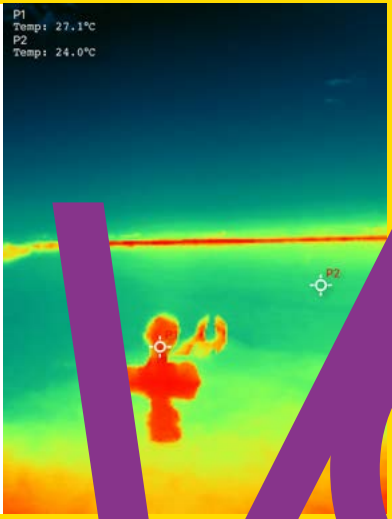

vol 69

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Welcome to

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Volume 69

Editorial

Architecture's most fundamental task has been to manage stress: designing structures that oppose gravitational pull through load-bearing and shaping spaces that transform the pressures of living and working into spaces we can inhabit. But architecture does not only manage stress; it also produces it – depleting materials through extraction, leaving exhausted landscapes in its wake, as well as overworked, stressed-out bodies in and around the profession.

For *VOLUME 69: Stress Management*, we examine how these pressures converge and how architecture both absorbs and exerts them. Stress is no longer only a technical question of load and resistance, but a condition that moves between bodies and relational ecosystems. Stress management becomes a lens through which bodily, social, and environmental systems can be understood together. In this issue, we look at how architecture can understand, absorb, adapt to, or relieve stress.

In this issue of *VOLUME*, stress appears in many different forms and situations. We encounter post-earthquake scaffolding that keeps buildings and cities in a prolonged state of suspension; migrant shelters that respond to stressed bodies through care, food, and rest; and the everyday stress of workplaces. Other contributions reflect on wellness infrastructures, ecological practices, fungal decay, lithium landscapes, data centers, and extractive territories, showing how stress is not always eliminated but displaced, redistributed, or maintained over time.

Alongside these examples, several contributions point towards affirmative approaches: practices of care and collaboration; and the repair of ecologies that give space to slow, collective practices that transform pressure into new forms of inhabitation, knowledge, and solidarity. Together, these projects reveal that stress is a condition that moves intrinsically through architecture's materiality, labor structures, and infrastructures, suggesting that it is a condition "we" can negotiate, redirect, and sometimes transform into more supportive ways of living and working together.

Yet, *V69's* approach to stress is not so solemn all of the time. While flipping through the pages of the magazine, you will find mandalas to color as a way to unwind, a crossword, a collection of objects for stress management, and quotes scattered throughout where architects index the everyday anxieties they encounter in their design practice – interruptions that create buffer zones to provide some form of relief. All of this in close collaboration with our new graphic designer, Miquel Hervás Gómez.

It's easy to find stress around us all, specifically at this moment – to manage it is something different. We hope this guide helps you navigate and manage these stressful times.

V69

by Stephan Petermann & María Mazzanti

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The Wall

by The Architecture Lobby

In preparation for the 2025 Biennale di Venezia, the Architecture Lobby interviewed 26 fellow organizers, intellectuals, and activist group leaders from around the world, creating an oral history of the emerging labor movement in the field of architecture. These interviews were screened in a "cubicle", complete with a desk and office chairs, in the main space of the international exhibition. On the exterior side of the stall, a supergraphic loudly exclaimed, in both English and Italian, "THANK YOU FOR YOUR UNPAID LABOR." On the inside back face were four broad labor-related questions and plenty of blank white space, inviting exhibition attendees to write their responses directly on the wall...

As we witnessed over the course of its 6-month run, this wall served to harvest the murmurs, outbursts, lizard-brain reactions, grievances (big and small), and other stress-releases of the collective psyche that makes-up the global architectural profession. Responses ranged from anecdotes of workplace conflict, political slogans, drawings, graffiti tags, comments in over 10 different languages, arguments between writers, several penises and cartooned caricatures, nonsensical phrases, and many more. By documenting what was on the tip of the tongue for those visiting the Venice Biennale, these walls allow us to peek into the collective *id* of the global architectural community. In sharp contrast to the panglossian thinking of that particular Biennale, and the intellectual sheen of architectural discourse, the comments reveal the desires, fears, and anxieties of the world's architects over issues of labor, technology, money, sex, climate, and power with an unfiltered honesty that only uncredited speech allows. Architects are burned out, angry, sometimes cynical, and often funny, but by and large they are doubtful of the future of our work, and our world.

The comments that were left are not how architects would describe themselves and the work they do if asked in any professional setting. Instead, they imply a collective discontent we typically dispel from the professional image that is projected out into the world. If we're going to organize architectural workers and make real change, these are the feelings we need to address.

WHAT UNPAID LABOR DO YOU DO AS AN ARCHITECTURAL WORKER?
QUALE LAVORO NON RETRIBUITO SVOLGI COME PROFESSIONISTA NEL SETTORE DELL'ARCHITETTURA?
WHAT ARE THE PROBLEMS YOU EXPERIENCE IN THE WORKPLACE AND WHAT ARE THE BARRIERS TO THEIR RESOLUTION?
QUALI SONO I PROBLEMI CHE AFFRONTI SUL POSTO DI LAVORO E QUALI OSTACOLI IMPEDISCONO LA LORO RISOLUZIONE?
MY WORK IS NOT PAID ENOUGH
UNSUSTAINABILITY
INEQUALITY
WHAT IS YOUR VISION FOR THE FUTURE OF THE INSTITUTIONS THAT REPRESENT, GOVERN AND SHAPE OUR PROFESSION?
QUAL È LA TUA VISIONE PER IL FUTURO DELLE ISTITUZIONI CHE RAPPRESENTANO, REGOLANO E PLASMANO LA NOSTRA PROFESSIONE?
LESS CORRUPTION
WHAT ACTION WILL YOU TAKE THIS YEAR TO BETTER YOUR POSITION AS AN ARCHITECTURAL WORKER?
QUALI AZIONI INTENDI INTRAPRENDERE QUEST'ANNO PER MIGLIORARE LA TUA CONDIZIONE COME PROFESSIONISTA NEL SETTORE DELL'ARCHITETTURA?

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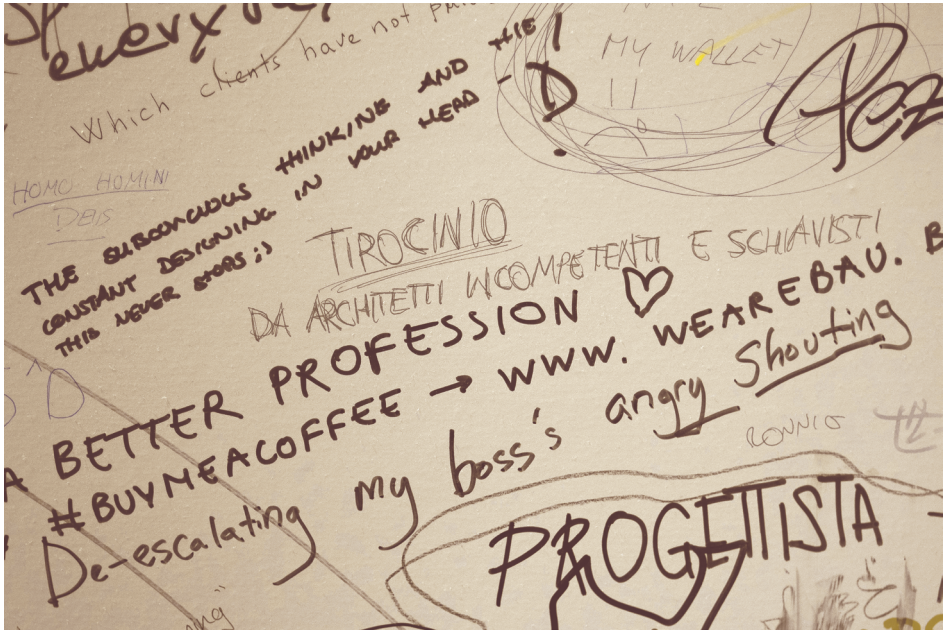
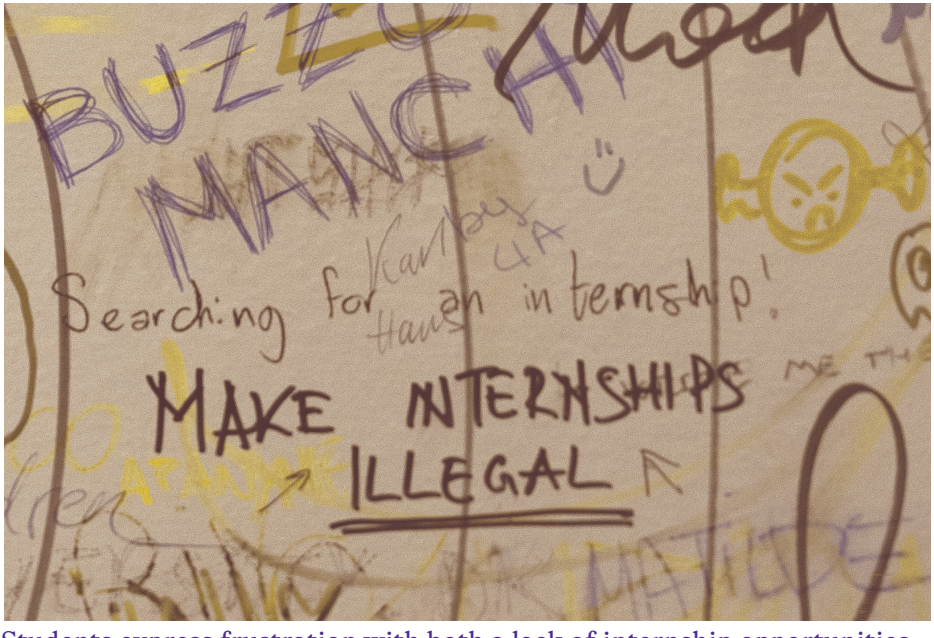
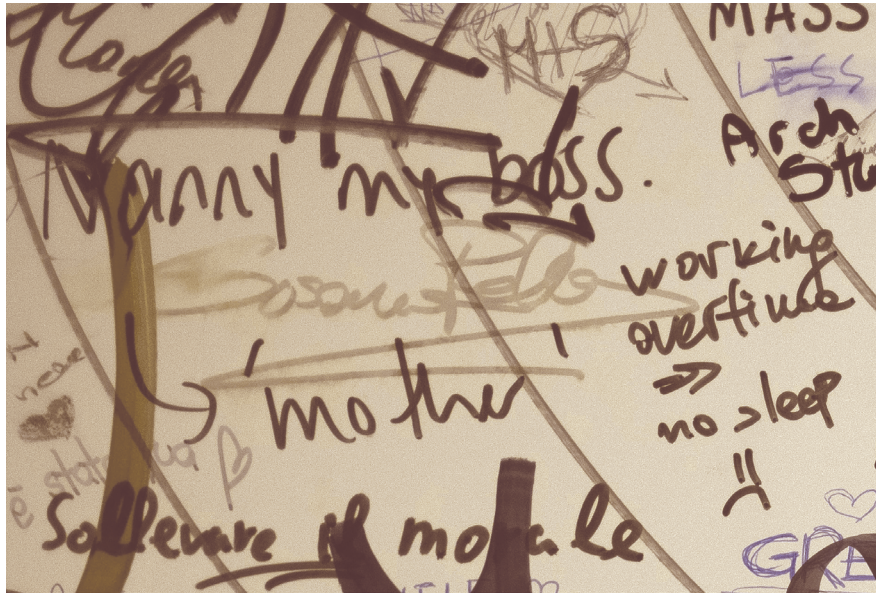
I WILL BUILD A BRIDGE OR
ON WALL



A comment in Italian reads , *"tirocinio da architetti incompetenti e schiavisti"* translating to "internship with incompetent and slave-driving architects", mirroring the English language comment below it.

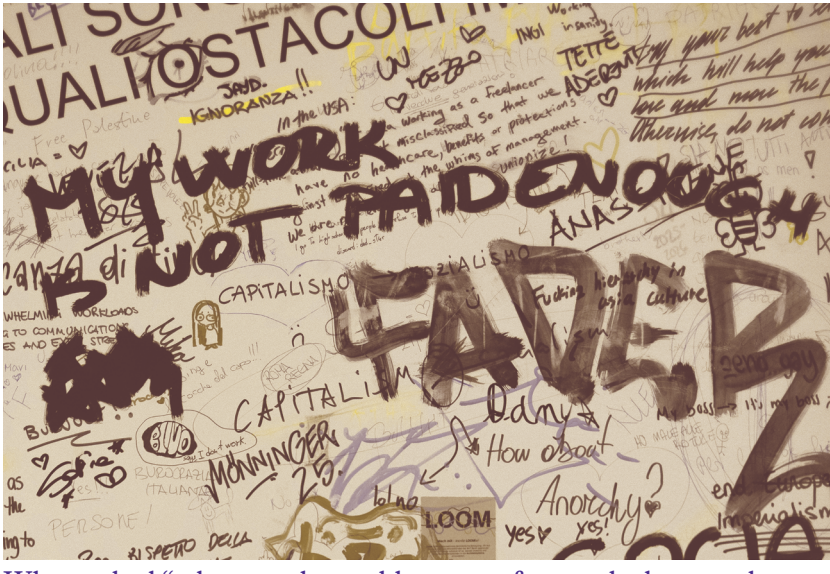


Students express frustration with both a lack of internship opportunities as well as the exploitative nature of these roles.

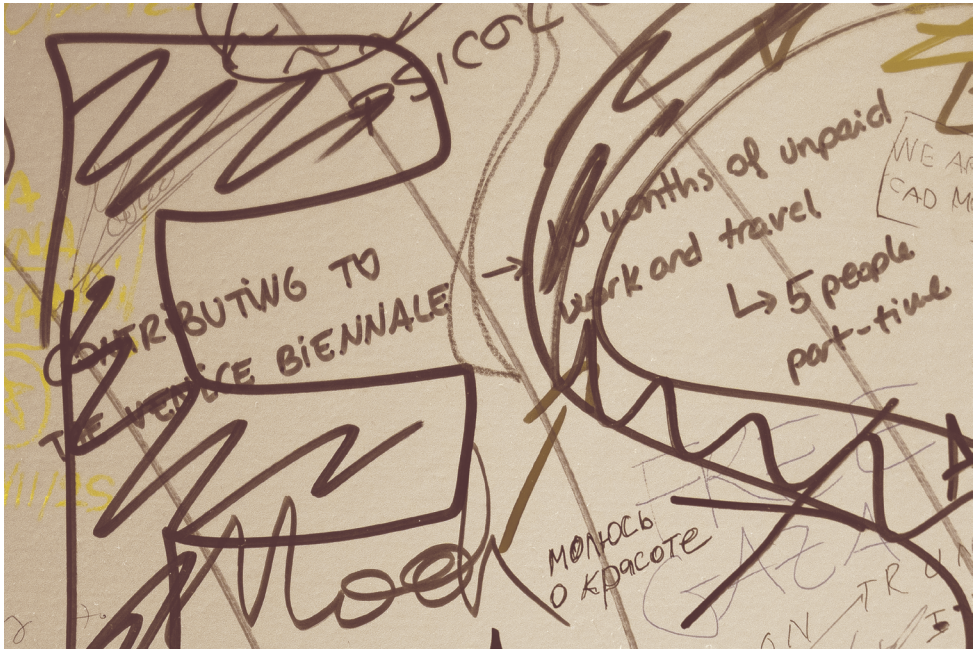


Bosses can be tyrants and also overly familiar – or familial. A surprising number of commenters mentioned having to "play therapist" or "conduct group therapy" for their bosses, clients, and contractors. Comments compare their relationships with their bosses with other familial or care work terms, such as "mothering," "baby-sit," or "nanny," and speaking of de-escalating childlike outbursts from those in charge.

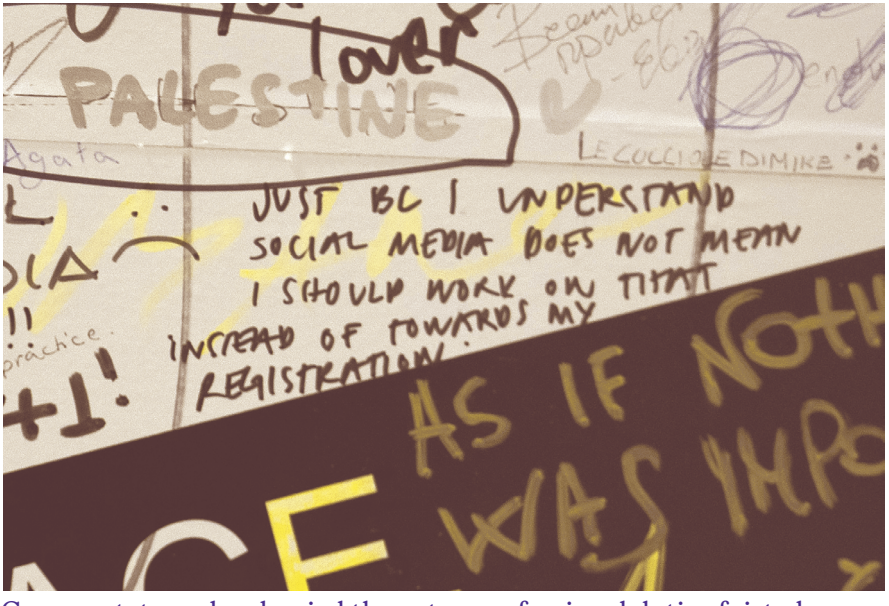
Overwork and Precarity



When asked "what are the problems you face and what are the barriers to solving them?" The largest number, more than a dozen commentators, flatly wrote that they just aren't being paid enough.

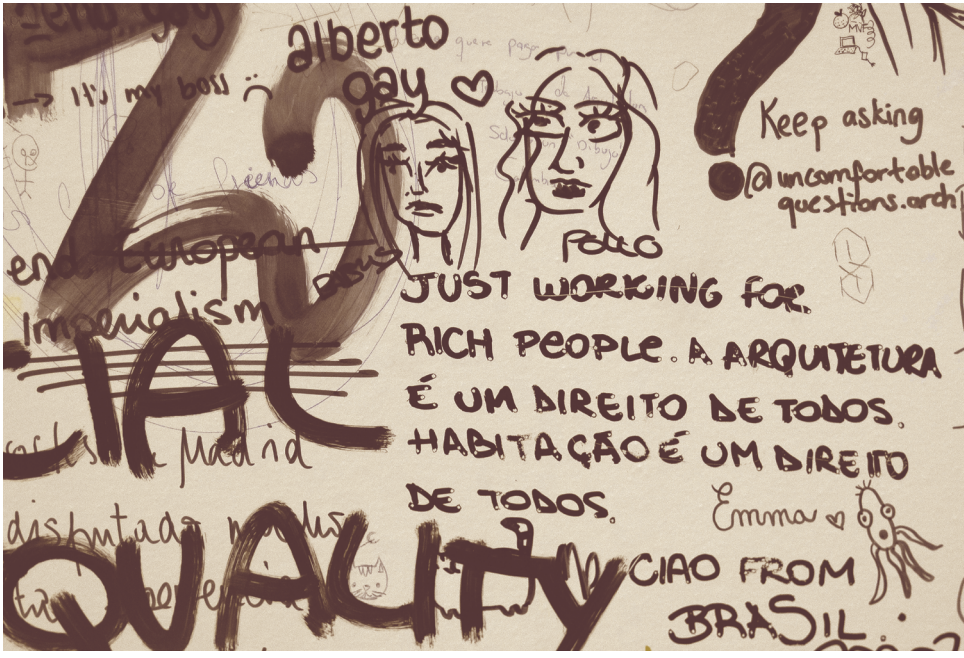


Some of the commenters expressed frustrations with the lack of compensation for their own work on the biennale, whether through "unpaid work and travel" or "build[ing] cultural capital for VeneZia."

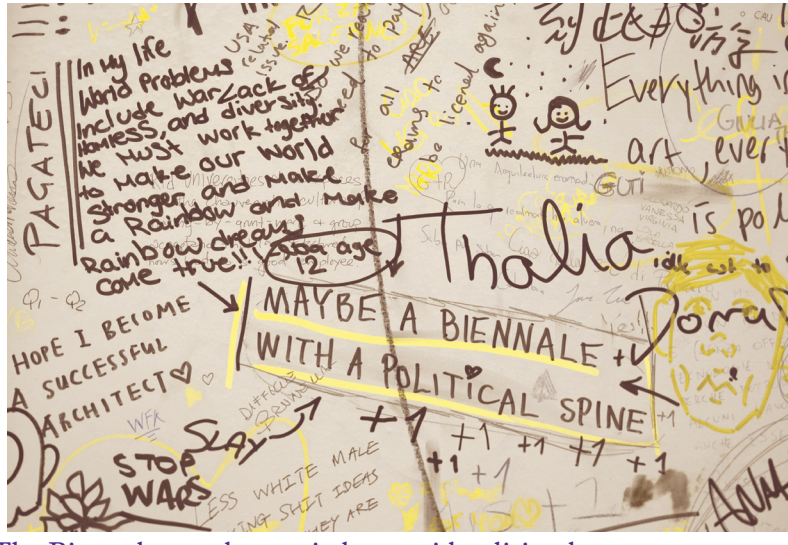


Commentators also decried the extra-professional duties foisted on architectural workers on top of contractual obligations such as "Design process in mind during leisure time,"; "Social media"; or "Cleaning the coffee machine."

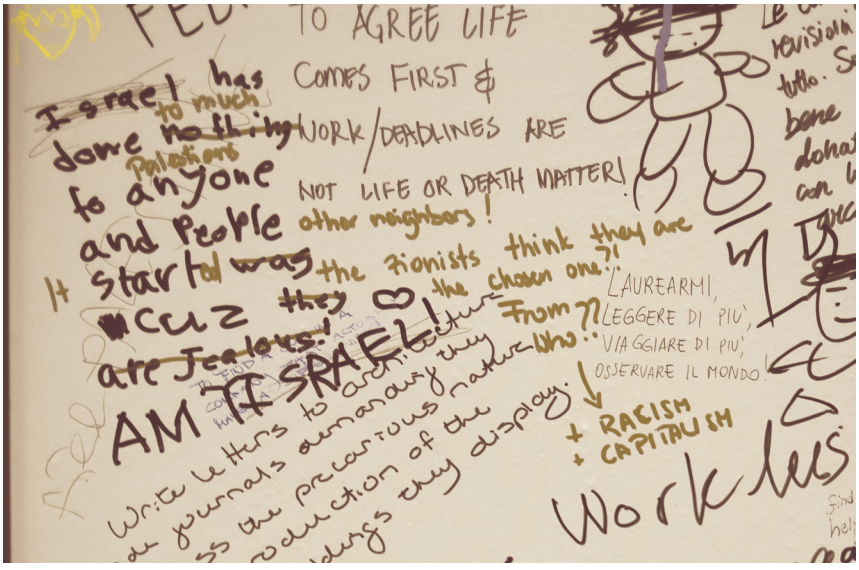
Optimism



In Portuguese, a comment decries having to work for the rich and then exclaims *"a arquitetura e um direito de todos habitacao um direito de todos"* which translates as "Architecture is a right for all; housing is a right for all."

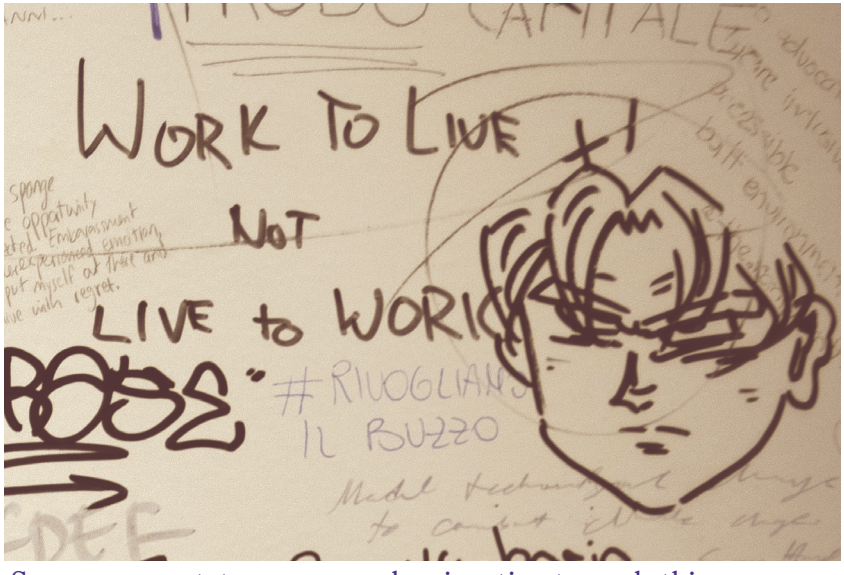


The Biennale may have tried to avoid politics, but many commenters clearly saw this gap – "How about a biennale with a political spine?" – and used their phrases to remind us that architecture is inseparable from politics.

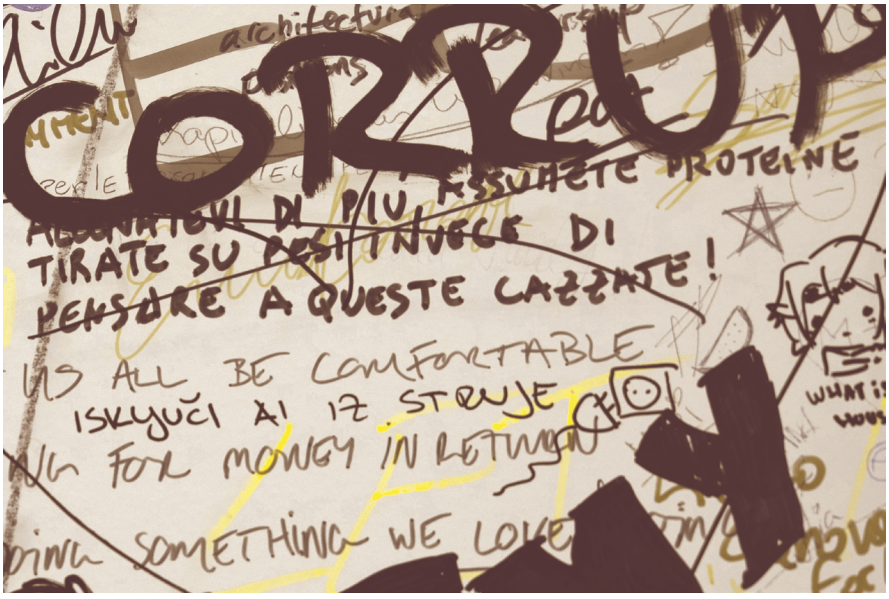


It's impossible to ignore the fact that commenters wrote more about their roles as global citizens, concerned with the actions of their governments (in particular regarding Palestine), and workers concerned with their working conditions, than about their roles as architects concerned with buildings.

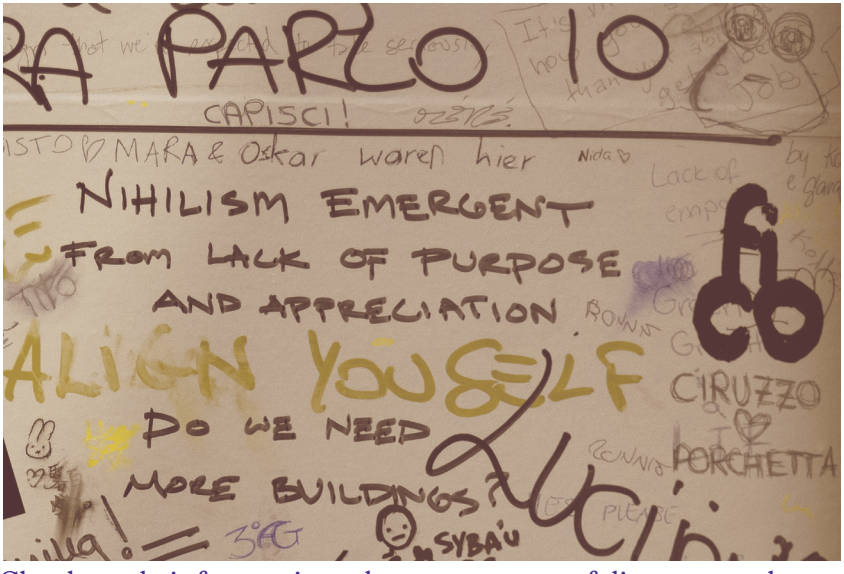
Despair



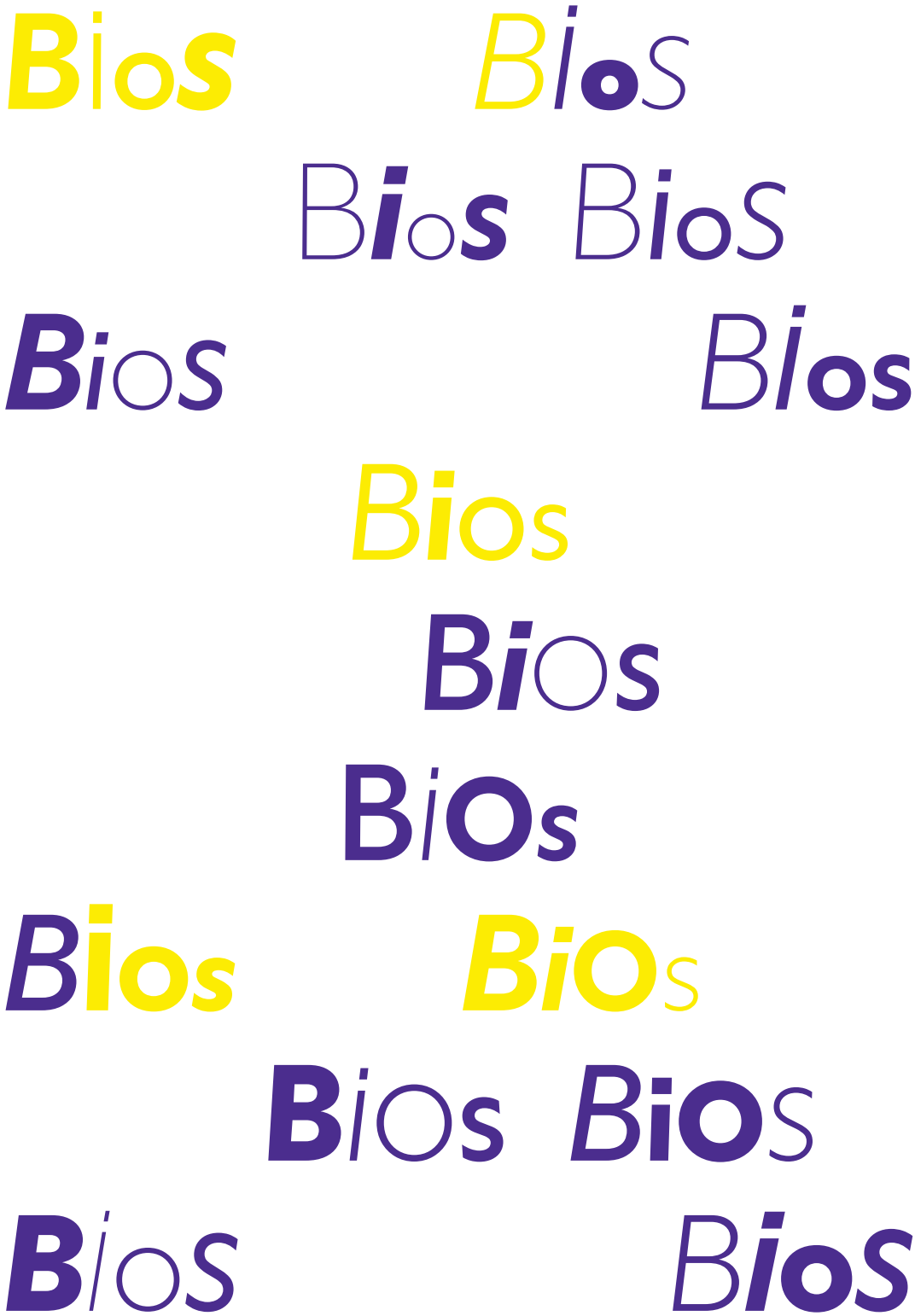
Some commentators expressed resignation towards this proletarianization of our discipline "Work to live! Not live to work" accompanying a drawing of Goku – the globally popular protagonist of *Dragon Ball Z* and symbol of perseverance and hope – feels like good advice in this predicament.



One Italian speaker took this attitude to its most cynical (if not anti-woke) self-deluding extreme, writing *"allenatevi di piu assunete protein tirate su pesi invece di pensare a queste cazzate"* translating to "Work out more, eat protein, lift weights instead of thinking about this bullshit."



Clearly as their frustrations show, no amount of discourse and spectacle at the biennale was enough to shake workers from this pessimism. A greater project of mass political and labor agitation must channel these harsh feelings – which seem totally contradictory yet, we believe, emanate from a shared sense of disconnection – if we want a better future for architecture across the globe. V 69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Ania Molenda is an architect, curator, writer, and educator. She is Programme Manager and Curator of Collections at the Nieuwe Instituut. Her work explores how technological, environmental, and social transformations shape spatial thinking and practice, guided by feminist principles and a commitment to care. She was a finalist for the Geert Bekaert Award for architectural criticism (2019) and co-recipient of the Dutch Design Award in Design Research (2018).

Céline Condorelli (It, Fr, Uk) is a London-based artist working across installations, sculptures, exhibitions, and architectures, exploring the structures of support that underpin human action and remain largely invisible. She was the 2023 National Gallery Artist in Residence and a founding director of Eastside Projects, Birmingham. Recent exhibitions include *In the Light of What We Know*, Remai Modern (2024), *Radical Playgrounds*, Gropius Bau (2024), and *Pentimenti (The Corrections)*, National Gallery (2023).

Chris Carroll has over 30 years' experience as a highly skilled structural engineer and influential building design leader at Arup. Chris delivers multidisciplinary projects globally that continually push boundaries and the value they bring to Arup's clients, collaborators, and wider society.

Francien van Westrenen is head of Agency at Nieuwe Instituut in Rotterdam (The Netherlands) and responsible for creating long term exchanges between designers living and working in the Netherlands and (inter)national platforms, manifestations and policymaking. She curated Who is We?, the exhibition in the Dutch pavilion at the 17th International Architecture Exhibition - La Biennale di Venezia (2021), with the work of Afaina de Jong and Debra Solomon.

Francesco Degl'Innocenti is pushing through.

Galena Sardamova is a curator and researcher based in Berlin. Her work examines post-socialist infrastructures in the Black Sea region through archival and spatial analysis, informed by questions of memory, place, and ritual. Originally from Bulgaria, she holds degrees from the Harvard Graduate School of Design and the University of Pennsylvania.

Geoffrey Timmer is Creative Director and co-founder of Nomen, an integrated spatial design practice working from research to realization, based in the Netherlands. His work sits at the intersection of organizational research, spatial identity, and materiality, with a particular interest in how the built environment shapes behavior and belonging. He writes and speaks on the role of space as a carrier of meaning in contemporary work culture.

Jack Farman is a French-American filmmaker based in Paris. His film series *Pioneer Species* is developed in collaboration with the Centre Pompidou as part of the Hors Pistes / Hors Champs exhibition. He is part of the Lina network, collaborating with institutions and on European projects to make films that follow communities and landscapes in the midst of urban and territorial transformation.

Klaas Kuitenbrouwer is heading the Zoönomic Institute and is a senior researcher in regenerative practices at Het Nieuwe Instituut in Rotterdam. He studied history but has always worked at the intersections of art, design, technology, and ecology. In his work as researcher and curator he is drawn to the frictions between different knowledge practices: technological, artistic, legal, organizational, scientific, and other-than-human.

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Lara Almarcegui (b. 1972, Es), living and working in Rotterdam, has been developing works over the course of twenty years that question the frontier between urban decay and urban renewal, making visible what tends to remain unnoticed. While focusing on abandoned spaces and structures that are undergoing a process of transformation, Almarcegui also investigates the different connections that can be established between architecture and urban planning. Through a continuous inquiry into the current state of peripheral areas, their development, use, and decay, Almarcegui sets up a discourse surrounding the diverse elements that constitute the physical reality of an ever-evolving urban landscape.

Lorenzo Rapisarda is an architecture graduate at Iuav University of Venice, currently completing a thesis centered on the concept of error and failure in architecture. His research investigates how architecture evolves under conditions of instability, exploring uncertainty as a catalyst for spatial transformation.

Manuel Orazi is an editor of architecture books for Quodlibet publishing house based in Macerata, Italy, and guest professor at Academy of Architecture in Mendrisio, Switzerland. He published with Yona Friedman, *The Dilution of Architecture*, Zurich, Park Books 2015, and curated the exhibition *Carlo Aymonino. Loyalty to Betrayal* at the Triennale of Milan in 2021.

Marco Vanucci is an architect and educator working at the intersection of computational design, architectural technology, and material systems. He is a PhD candidate at Rmit University and leads design studios at London South Bank University and Anglia Ruskin University, with previous teaching at the Architectural Association and Kth Stockholm. He is the founder of Opensystems Architecture, a London-based practice recognized for research-led work across architecture, installations, and product design, and is a prolific writer on technology, automation, and the city.

María Mazzanti is an architect, editor, and educator based in Amsterdam. She works across publishing, critical spatial practices, writing, and storytelling, often collaboratively, translating research into public formats, communicative objects, and publishing frameworks for collective engagement. She is the managing editor of *VOLUME*.

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Michelle Gulickx is an art historian specialized in content strategy and storytelling for the built environment. Her clients include the University of Amsterdam, Arcam, Unstudio, and Architour. As a writer and columnist, she regularly contributes to industry publications and is a co-host of the podcast Landmassa.

Miquel Hervás Gómez is a graphic designer and pedagogue based on the Www. He works as a link between experimental publishing, typography, tools, and visual communication. Agitator for the Preparatory Course at the Gerrit Rietveld Academie as well as other international universities. He is a former member of Carne Kids, now acting as a workshop specialist at the Bb and giving design direction at fanfare. Miquel is the designer of *VOLUME* magazine.

Nuria Ribas Costa is an independent journalist, jurist, and urbanist based between Rotterdam and Ibiza, where she is originally from. She is also an editor, moderator, cultural programmer, and DJ, co-founder of Revista078, and writes for independent media.

Olaf Grawert plans, writes, and talks about architecture. His work focuses on the Poetics and Politics of Space: the political and economic conditions, as well as the imaginaries and narratives that shape the built environment. Collaborating with a network of individuals and institutions across Europe, he develops projects that bridge theory and practice, including building design, campaigns, exhibitions, films, publications, and teaching.

Paris Bezanis is an architect and researcher based in Berlin. His work combines spatial analysis and digital capture techniques to study ecological transformation in post-socialist landscapes, with a current focus on the Black Sea region. He is a graduate of the University of Chicago and the Harvard Graduate School of Design.

Piergiorgio Boscaro is a graduate in architecture from Iuav University of Venice and a photographer. His research explores architecture as a limit-experience, focusing on its manifestation in pathological states, where it oscillates between acts of renunciation and moments of chaotic explosion.

Pietro Fabris is a graduate architecture student at Iuav University of Venice. He investigates sociotechnical relationships in architecture, with a particular focus on the role of technology as both a design agent and an inhabitant of built space.

Rosi Braidotti is an internationally recognised philosopher and Distinguished University Professor Emerita at Utrecht University. Her main book publications are *The Posthuman* (2013); *Posthuman Knowledge* (2019); *Posthuman Feminism* (2022); *Nomadic Subjects* (2011) *and Nomadic Theory* (2011). She collaborates with the New Institute with the project of the New Academy.

Serena De Mola is based between Bari and Venice, and holds a master degree in visual communication design at Iuav University of Venice. Since 2024, she has been a PhD student in graphic design at the same university. Her practice focuses on the relationships between design and its possible sociopolitical variations, with an intersectional feminist perspective.

Stefano Dealessandri is a Rotterdam-based visual and spatial storyteller working across design, research, and craft. His practice draws on studies and professional experience in Hamburg, Jerusalem, Venice, and The Hague.

Stephan Petermann (NL/Ger) worked for *VOLUME* in 2005.

The Architecture Lobby is a member-driven activist organization that advocates for just labor practices and an equitable built environment.

Tio Gabunia is an Architect, Urbanist, and Researcher. Tio currently teaches at the School of Visual Art, Architecture and Design (Va[a]ds) of Free University and the International Black Sea University. He is also a practicing architect and project manager.

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Volume 69:
Stress Management

VOLUME Independent magazine
for architecture, design, and beyond.
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In 2004, Archis, the Amsterdam-based architecture magazine with a pedigree reaching back to 1929, joined forces with OMA's think tank AMO and C-Lab – a think-tank at the GSAPP of Columbia University – based on the shared ambition to redefine and re-establish architecture's relevance. **VOLUME** was created by Archis Editor in Chief at the time, Ole Bouman in collaboration with Rem Koolhaas (AMO) and Mark Wigley (Dean of GSAPP). From 2017, Archis/**VOLUME** changed its structure into more theme-based forms of collaboration, expanding the network of partners. Since 2023, **VOLUME** is a collaboration between Archis and Nieuwe Instituut.

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Museum for architecture, design, and digital culture.

Nieuwe Instituut

Nel Verschuuren – Kho Liang le Associates Archive, Collection Nieuwe Instituut. Photo: Johannes Schwartz.

J. Gratama, G. Versteeg & J.W. Dinger Archive. Drawing and blueprint, 1933-1934. Collection Nieuwe Instituut. Photo: Johannes Schwartz.

Nieuwe Instituut is the national museum and institute for architecture, design and digital culture. From exhibitions and public programmes to research projects, the National Collection and (inter)national initiatives like Network Archives Design and Digital Culture. We offer inspiration, tools, resources and networks that bridge past, present and future practice. Discover how Nieuwe Instituut can inspire your practice. nieuweinstituut.nl. Museum for architecture, design and digital culture.

uME

V69: Stress Management

Architecture is built on pressure. It resists gravity and structures how we live and work, but it also produces stress through extraction, overproduction, and the exhaustion of materials, landscapes, and bodies. From scaffolding and shelters to workplaces, data centres, and extractive territories, *V69* traces how stress is absorbed, displaced and managed while pointing toward practices of care, collaboration, and repair that suggest other ways of living and working under pressure.